

2026 Orbital Market Entry Report

Q2 / Q3 Update (v5 — full width) · Sector: Space Launch Services & Orbital Infrastructure

Effective Date: May 15, 2026 · Prepared by Vlad Algin · Orbital Economics

Editor's Note — What Changed Since February

The February 2026 baseline of this report remains structurally sound, but several developments since publication materially shift the picture for capital, customers, and contract pipelines. This Q2/Q3 update layers those changes onto the original framework rather than replacing it. Treat all market-size figures as directional; the methodology gap across research houses has widened, not narrowed, since February. All factual claims in this update are cited in Appendix A.

The Six Q2/Q3 Shifts

- 1. SpaceX IPO mechanics activated.** Confidential S-1 filed April 1, 2026 (confirmed by Bloomberg, CNBC, Reuters, WSJ); analyst meetings April 21–23; public S-1 expected May 18–22 per the SEC's 15-day pre-roadshow rule; roadshow week of June 8; target debut June 2026 on Nasdaq (ticker SPCE); reported \$1.75T–\$2T valuation; reported \$75B raise. [§ A.1]
- 2. SpaceX absorbed xAI.** SpaceX acquired xAI in February 2026; as of early May, xAI is being dissolved into "SpaceXAI." The IPO entity is now a rockets + Starlink + frontier-AI company. [§ A.2]
- 3. Orbital compute named publicly** in two on-record events: Starcloud and Cowboy Space unicorn rounds, plus Anthropic's May 6 deal with SpaceXAI for all of Colossus 1's 220K+ GPUs — with Anthropic publicly stating interest in multi-gigawatt orbital compute with SpaceX. [§ A.2, A.3]
- 4. New Glenn grounded.** NG-3 (April 19) achieved first booster reuse but the upper stage failed and BlueBird 7 was lost. FAA grounded New Glenn pending investigation. [§ A.4]
- 5. Rocket Lab Neutron** slipped to no-earlier-than Q4 2026 after a Q1 tank test failure, but won a five-Neutron + three-Electron block deal on May 7. Q1 backlog: \$2.2B. [§ A.5]
- 6. FY27 White House NASA request** repeats the \$18.8B FY26 ask Congress already rejected. Two consecutive WH requests now formalize the commercial-first lunar pivot. [§ A.6]

1. Market Overview & Key Metrics — Refreshed

The Q1 baseline of \$24–\$32B for the 2026 space launch services market still holds across the major research houses. What has shifted is cadence and concentration, not size:

- **2026 is on track to be the busiest launch year ever**, with industry trackers projecting 250+ orbital launches globally. SpaceX alone had completed 51 Falcon 9 flights by mid-May. [§ A.7]
- **SpaceX share remains ~50%+ of global commercial launch** by mass. Both New Glenn's April grounding and Neutron's Q4 slip extend SpaceX's dominant window. [§ A.7]
- **Starlink crossed 10M subscribers in February 2026** (up from 9M in December 2025); 10,000+ satellites operational and 65% of all active satellites. [§ A.8]
- **China** is sustaining 50+ launches annually, with Long March 12B and Landspace's Zhuque-2E expanding the indigenous commercial stack. [§ A.7]

Metric	Q1 2026 Baseline	Q2/Q3 2026 Update
Launch services market size	~\$24–\$32B	Range holds; cadence accelerating
Global 2026 launch cadence	~200+ projected	On pace for 250+ orbital launches
SpaceX share of commercial launch	>40% revenue	~50%+ by mass; 51 F9 flights by mid-May
LEO share of activity	63–67%	Holding; megaconstellations dominant
Starlink subscribers	~9M (Dec 2025)	10M+ (Feb 2026); 10,000+ satellites operational
Regional leader (revenue)	North America >40%	Concentration deepening, not diluting

2. US Government Priorities — Two Budget Cycles to Track

The February report covered FY26 with the appropriate disaggregation: the \$24.4B base appropriation (House passed Jan 8, Senate Jan 15) plus the OBBBA supplemental contribution. That picture is intact. What is new is the FY27 White House request released in April 2026. [§ A.6]

Budget Reality Check — FY27

- The White House FY27 NASA request is **\$18.8B** — the same top-line it requested for FY26 and that Congress largely rejected. The proposal repeats deep cuts to Science (40+ missions eliminated) and ISS (~\$1.1B), while protecting Artemis (\$8.5B) and adding \$175M for a robotic lunar base-camp pathfinder. [§ A.6]
- **Investor read:** history suggests Congress will again push back. The relevant trend for capital allocation is not the headline number but the consistent directional signal — outsource lunar transport to commercial, sunset SLS/Orion after Artemis III, transition ISS to commercial LEO destinations.
- **SLS/Orion retirement after Artemis III** is now in two consecutive White House requests. Suppliers and primes downstream of those programs should treat this as a structural, not cyclical, signal. [§ A.6]

Golden Dome — From PowerPoint to Procurement

OBBBA authorized ~\$25B initial investment for Golden Dome (signed July 2025), with another \$500M earmarked for military space launch infrastructure. The FY27 DoD request would push total defense resources to \$1.5T, with space called out explicitly. 2026 is the year contract awards begin in volume; Q2/Q3 2026 is the window where narrative converts to fundamentals. [§ A.9]

- **Rocket Lab** already landed an \$805M Space Development Agency deal (Dec 2025) — the company's largest ever, ~50% larger than its 2024 total revenue. [§ A.5]
- **BlackSky** backlog stands at ~\$322.7M with 91% international government share — a useful tell on where allied procurement is flowing. [§ A.5]
- **SpaceX continues to dominate task orders.** In January 2026, the Space Force awarded \$739M in NSSL task orders solely to SpaceX for nine missions. [§ A.10]

Mars and Deep Space — Still a Negative Signal

Mars Sample Return remains effectively cancelled. The FY27 request continues to redirect Mars investment toward a human-class lander pathway and commercial communications relay — favorable for SpaceX Starship economics, unfavorable for legacy deep-space science mission suppliers. [§ A.6]

3. Launch Market Pricing & Emerging Providers — Q2/Q3 Realities

SpaceX

Through May 14, 2026: 51 Falcon 9 flights, including 44 dedicated Starlink missions. Starship V3 (Flight 12) debut targeted for May 19, 2026 from Launch Pad 2 at Starbase — the first Starship flight of 2026 after a months-long pause (Ship last flew October 2025). Booster 19 will splash down in the Gulf rather than attempt catch; Ship 39 will deploy 22 Starlink simulators on a suborbital trajectory. Raptor 3 engines and Pad 2 infrastructure are unproven in flight. The mission tests vehicle and infrastructure changes intended to support Artemis 3 in 2027. [§ A.11]

Blue Origin — New Glenn Grounded

NG-3 (April 19, 2026) is a study in mixed outcomes. The first stage flew on the booster that flew NG-2 in November 2025 — first successful reuse for the program, making Blue Origin only the second Western company to land and re-fly an orbital-class booster. But the upper stage malfunctioned (one engine “didn’t produce sufficient thrust,” per Blue Origin CEO Dave Limp), AST SpaceMobile’s BlueBird 7 satellite was placed in a low parking orbit and will be deorbited as a write-off. [§ A.4]

FAA has grounded New Glenn pending a formal mishap investigation. Blue Origin’s 2026 manifest — Blue Moon Mark 1 demo lander targeted for this fall and one to two Amazon Kuiper missions — is now contingent on the investigation outcome. Blue Origin also announced a West Coast facility (SLC-14 at Vandenberg) for polar orbits and holds an NSSL Phase 3 Lane 2 contract worth ~\$2.4B across 7 anticipated flights. [§ A.4]

Rocket Lab — Neutron Slipped but Commercial Momentum Strong

Neutron first flight has been pushed to no earlier than Q4 2026 following a first-stage tank test failure earlier in the year. The first flight will not be reusable; recovery is targeted on flight two. On May 7, the company announced a block deal for five Neutron launches plus three Electron launches to an undisclosed customer — a contract value Rocket Lab said exceeds their previous record (a \$190M DoD Haste contract). Q1 2026 backlog: \$2.2B, with launches representing 41.5% of that. Space systems revenue has grown from 6% of company revenue in 2020 to ~75% today — Rocket Lab is now an end-to-end integrator first, launcher second. [§ A.5]

Stoke Space — Pacific Northwest to Florida

Stoke Space is one of the most under-covered competitive threats to SpaceX in the medium-lift category, and its operating footprint is more interesting than its press coverage suggests. The company is headquartered in Kent, Washington (168,000 sq ft factory + mission control), and runs its 75-acre Moses Lake Test Site three hours east of Kent — where it tests its Zenith first-stage engines, Andromeda upper-stage cluster, and conducted the September 2023 “Hopper2” VTVL flight. The Moses Lake → Kent → Cape Canaveral pipeline is the operational logic: test and iterate engines in Moses Lake, integrate vehicles in Kent, transport cross-country to SLC-14 in Florida for launch. [§ A.12]

- **Funding profile:** Series D total raised to ~\$860M (Oct 2025 \$510M + Feb 2026 \$350M extension); cumulative ~\$1.34B to date. Backers include US Innovative Technology Fund, Breakthrough Energy, Toyota Ventures, 776, Glade Brook Capital. [§ A.12]

- **Government track:** Selected for the \$5.6B NSSL Phase 3 Lane 1 program in March 2025, allowing competition for a decade of national security launch contracts alongside SpaceX and Blue Origin. [§ A.12]
- **Launch site:** SLC-14 at Cape Canaveral — historic Mercury-Atlas pad (John Glenn's 1962 orbital flight) — refurbished in just under one year. First Nova launch targeted for sometime in 2026. [§ A.12]
- **Technical differentiation:** Nova is designed for 100% reusability. Payload capacity ~3 tonnes to LEO. If Nova flies, it would be the first medium-lift vehicle in the world with a fully reusable upper stage.

The strategic frame: Stoke is the Pacific Northwest's most credible end-to-end launch competitor. The Moses Lake → Kent → Florida operating pipeline reflects something important about Washington State's competitive position in space — the engineering talent base, test infrastructure access, and proximity to Blue Origin and Amazon LEO are creating a regional cluster that mirrors what California built around SpaceX in the 2010s.

ULA, Firefly, Others

- **ULA Vulcan** remains under an anomaly investigation after a February 2026 in-flight SRB issue; a successful GEM 63XL static fire was confirmed May 14. [§ A.7]
- **Firefly Aerospace** announced a Lockheed Martin / Seagate collaboration for ocean-based Alpha launches (May 4) — a structurally novel cadence play. [§ A.7]
- **Relativity Space** Terran R targets late 2026 first launch from LC-16 at Cape Canaveral — next door to Stoke's LC-14. [§ A.12]
- **Ariane 6** is reaching full European operational cadence in 2026. [§ A.7]

4. Investment & Return Opportunities — The Orbital Compute Wave

This is the section that has changed most since February. Orbital compute is no longer a speculative sub-sector in the report's risk language — in Q1/Q2 2026 it became a fundable category with named winners and named customers.

A. The SpaceX Pre-IPO Halo — Now an AI + Space Story

Two structural facts changed the SpaceX IPO narrative this quarter. First, SpaceX acquired xAI in February 2026 and as of early May is dissolving it into "SpaceXAI." The Colossus 1 supercomputer (220,000+ NVIDIA GPUs, 300+ MW) is now a SpaceX asset, with SpaceXAI having moved its own training to Colossus 2. Second, the SpaceX pitch to public-market investors now explicitly includes frontier AI as a growth vector, not just rockets and Starlink. The reported \$1.75T–\$2T valuation is being justified on a rocket + satellite-broadband + AI-infrastructure thesis. [§ A.1, A.2]

Important caveat for investors: historically, the largest IPOs underperform in their first 6–12 months (Saudi Aramco, Alibaba, Facebook). The IPO is a high-confidence catalyst event; the post-listing trade is not necessarily a high-confidence long. The halo effect on adjacent pre-IPO names (Axiom Space, Stoke Space, Relativity) remains intact.

B. Orbital Data Centers — The Q2 2026 Funding Cascade

Three on-record events in roughly six weeks materially changed the orbital-compute investability story:

- **Starcloud Series A — \$170M @ \$1.1B post-money (March 30, 2026).** Led by Benchmark and EQT Ventures. Y Combinator's fastest-ever unicorn. Already deployed an NVIDIA H100 in LEO (November 2025) — first AI training in orbit. Crusoe is named as first commercial customer, with partnerships disclosed with AWS, Google Cloud, and NVIDIA. FCC plans for an 88,000-satellite constellation. CEO Philip Johnston's threshold: orbital compute beats terrestrial economics at ~\$500/kg launch cost in 2028–2029. [§ A.13]
- **Cowboy Space Series B — \$275M @ \$2B post-money (May 11, 2026).** Led by Index Ventures; joined by Breakthrough Energy, IVP, NEA, SAIC, a16z, Blossom Capital. Total raised ~\$365M per CEO Baiju Bhatt. Differentiator: data center built into the rocket upper stage — 1 MW per module, ~800 GPUs, 20–25 tonnes. First satellite (power-beaming demo) targeted for later in 2026; first Cowboy rocket targeted 2028. [§ A.14]
- **Anthropic × SpaceXAI deal (May 6, 2026).** Anthropic gains all of Colossus 1's capacity — 220,000+ NVIDIA GPUs, 300+ MW. **Crucially: Anthropic publicly named interest in working with SpaceX to develop “multiple gigawatts of compute capacity in space.”** This is the first time a frontier AI lab has publicly named orbital compute in a binding partnership announcement. [§ A.3]

Read for Vlad / Orbit2Orbit / LEDC: The orbital-compute category is now where capital is flowing in eight-figure cheques — but every public valuation depends on Starship reaching ~\$500/kg launch cost in 2028–2029. The category is fundable as a story; it is not yet fundable on fundamentals. The terrestrial-LEO operators are competing on power-in-orbit and radiator surface area — exactly the constraints that the LEDC lunar architecture sidesteps with bored thermal sinks and PSR placement. **Anthropic publicly naming gigawatt-scale orbital compute is the strongest narrative tailwind LEDC has received this year.**

C. Public Market Leaders — Update

Company	Ticker	Q2/Q3 2026 Read
Planet Labs	NYSE: PL	Backlog growth; daily AI geospatial remains baseline
Intuitive Machines	NASDAQ: LUNR	CLPS pipeline intact; Artemis commercial pivot favors
AST SpaceMobile	NASDAQ: ASTS	D2D thesis intact; BlueBird 7 loss is short-term setback
Rocket Lab	NASDAQ: RKL	Neutron Q4 slip + 5N/3E deal + \$805M SDA; integrator pivot
BlackSky	NYSE: BKS	~\$322.7M backlog, 91% int'l — allied gov't tell

D. High-Signal Sub-Sectors — May 2026

- **Orbital compute / Edge AI** — fundable category with named unicorns and on-record AI-lab interest.
- **Sovereign security** — Golden Dome RFP-to-contract conversion is the Q2/Q3 catalyst. [§ A.9]
- **Space-based data centers (lunar / deep orbit)** — still pre-commercial. Anthropic's public naming of gigawatt-scale orbital compute is a structural tailwind.
- **Optical communications & ISL** — every orbital compute thesis depends on it. TESAT, Mynaric, BridgeComm, CACI are direct beneficiaries.
- **In-space power (beaming, solar, nuclear)** — Star Catcher raised \$65M. Cowboy Space is doing power beaming.

- **Reusability — SpaceX baseline, industry differentiator.** For SpaceX, reusability is the baseline. For everyone else, demonstrated reusability remains a real competitive differentiator.

5. IPO & Major Investment Calendar — H2 2026

The 2026 IPO window is unusually catalyst-dense for space and AI infrastructure investors. SpaceX is the headline event, but it sits inside a tighter cluster of listings and capital events than most observers appreciate.

A. SpaceX IPO — The Calendar

Milestone	Date / Window	Implication
Confidential S-1 filed with SEC	April 1, 2026 (confirmed)	Clock started; SEC review window underway
Closed-door analyst meetings	April 21–23, 2026 (reported)	Long-term growth story laid out to institutionals
Public S-1 filing expected	May 18–22, 2026 (derived)	Financials become public; first valuation pressure-test
IPO roadshow begins	Week of June 8, 2026 (reported)	Pricing conversations; secondary-market reads
Target IPO debut	June 2026 base case (Q3–Q4 possible)	Largest IPO in history if executed on plan
Target listing venue	Nasdaq (ticker: SPCE) (reported)	Nasdaq 100 inclusion possible within 15 days of listing
180-day lockup ends	Roughly Dec 15–27, 2026	Insider supply enters — historic price pressure point

Underwriter syndicate (reported): Bank of America, Citigroup, Goldman Sachs, JPMorgan Chase, Morgan Stanley as senior leads, with up to 21 underwriters total. Target raise: \$75B. Target valuation: \$1.75T–\$2T per Bloomberg (March 2026). Retail allocation: reportedly up to 30% — unprecedented for a deal this size. [§ A.1]

Caveats. The public S-1 filing date (May 18–22) is derived from the SEC’s rule requiring a public prospectus at least 15 days before a roadshow. Most details remain unconfirmed by SpaceX. Historical pattern: the largest IPOs typically underperform in their first 6–12 months.

B. Other Major 2026 IPOs Worth Tracking

Company	Sector	Target Window	Target Valuation
SpaceX	Space / AI	June 2026 (H2 base case)	\$1.75T–\$2T
Databricks	AI / Data infrastructure	Q3 2026; S-1 mid-summer	~\$134B
OpenAI	AI	Q4 2026 (Nov–Dec)	~\$850B
Anthropic	AI	October 2026 target	~\$380B–\$900B
Discord	Social / Gaming	Mid-2026	~\$15B

Company	Sector	Target Window	Target Valuation
Kraken	Crypto	Q3 2026 (delayed from Q1)	~\$20B
Monzo	Fintech / UK listing	Q2–Q3 2026 dependent on FCA	~\$8B
Plaid	Fintech	S-1 filed Q1 2026	~\$6.1B
LandSpace (China)	Space launch	Late 2026 potential	~\$1B

Source: § A.15. The structural tell: the three AI mega-IPOs (SpaceX + OpenAI + Anthropic) represent ~\$3T+ in combined target market cap.

C. Recent Private Capital Events (Space)

Company	Event	Amount	Date
Cowboy Space	Series B	\$275M @ \$2B post-money	May 11, 2026
Starcloud	Series A	\$170M @ \$1.1B post-money	March 30, 2026
Stoke Space	Series D extension	Total round to ~\$860M; \$1.34B cumulative	Oct 2025 / Feb 2026
Axiom Space	Private round	\$350M (Type One / QIA-led)	February 2026
CesiumAstro	Equity + gov't debt	\$470M + \$200M gov-backed	Early 2026
Star Catcher	Series	\$65M for orbital power beaming	Q1 2026
Orbital (a16z Speedrun)	Accelerator	Undisclosed (~\$1M typical)	Q1 2026
Vantor	NGA Luno B contract win	Contract — not equity	Q1 2026

Action items from the IPO calendar:

1. If you plan to tap Orbital Economics readership ahead of the SpaceX S-1 (expected May 18–22), the editorial window is now.
2. Sovereign / Gulf SWF conversations for LEDC should reference the AI-IPO supercycle as context. Mubadala and PIF read these calendars carefully.
3. The Anthropic public naming of multi-gigawatt orbital compute is a free editorial gift. Frame it carefully: terrestrial-LEO is now the proven story; lunar surface is the next architectural frontier.
4. Watch the SpaceX 180-day lockup expiry (Dec 15–27, 2026). That falls inside the LEDC fundraising window.

6. Key Risks & Corrections — Updated for Q2/Q3

- **Market sizing methodology gap has widened.** Some research houses now report space launch services in the hundreds of billions; others retain the \$24–\$32B narrow scope. Always verify scope before citing. [§ A.17]
- **Orbital compute story can run ahead of the engineering.** Radiation, cooling, latency, and launch economics are real constraints. Starcloud's own CEO is on record that cost-competitive orbital compute requires ~\$500/kg launch and won't arrive until 2028–2029. None of these are demonstrated at scale today. [§ A.13]
- **SpaceX IPO timing is reported, not confirmed.** Confidential S-1 is filed; everything else is reported timing from unnamed sources. Mega-IPOs historically underperform in months 1–12. [§ A.1]
- **NASA budget — FY27 fragility.** The administration is asking for the same cuts Congress rejected last cycle. Model FY27 outcomes with wide uncertainty bands. [§ A.6]
- **Concentration risk on SpaceX has deepened, not normalized.** The Pacific Northwest cluster (Stoke, Blue Origin, Amazon LEO, Starcloud) is the most credible source of medium-term competition.
- **Anthropic-Pentagon litigation.** Anthropic was declared a Pentagon supply chain risk in March 2026 and is in active litigation. [§ A.3]
- **Tariffs and supply chain.** Research and Markets is explicitly noting tariff impacts on imported aerospace components, electronics, and advanced materials. [§ A.17]

7. Forward Look — Catalyst Calendar Through H2 2026

Window	Catalyst	Why It Matters
May 18–22, 2026	SpaceX public S-1 expected	Financials become public — first valuation pressure-test
May 19, 2026	Starship V3 / Flight 12 debut	First Starship of 2026; gates Artemis 3 and Starlink v3
May 2026	Vast Haven-1 station launch (target)	Commercial LEO destination race signal
June 8, 2026 (week of)	SpaceX IPO roadshow begins	Pricing conversations; secondary-market reads
Q2/Q3 2026	Golden Dome contract awards	Converts narrative to fundamentals; primes RKL, BKS
June 2026 (base case)	SpaceX IPO debut on Nasdaq (SPCE)	Re-rates entire public space sector
Summer 2026	Databricks S-1 expected	AI-infrastructure listing cluster begins
2026 (TBD)	FAA decision on New Glenn return-to-flight	Gates Blue Moon Mark 1 and Amazon Kuiper deployment
2026	Stoke Space Nova first flight from LC-14	First fully-reusable medium-lift attempt
H2 2026	FY27 appropriations debate in Congress	Will Congress again reject the \$18.8B WH request?
Q4 2026 NET	Rocket Lab Neutron first flight	First credible medium-lift competitor to F9

Window	Catalyst	Why It Matters
October 2026	Anthropic IPO target	AI compute thesis tested in public market
Q4 2026 (Nov-Dec)	OpenAI IPO target	Largest AI listing window
Late 2026	Blue Moon Mark 1 first robotic landing	Tests New Glenn-to-surface pathway
Dec 15-27, 2026	SpaceX 180-day lockup ends	Insider supply enters — volatility event
Throughout 2026	Orbital compute demos / failures	Starcloud 2, Cowboy first sat, Google Suncatcher

Bottom line for Q2/Q3 2026. The framework of the February report is intact. What has changed is the activation of the SpaceX IPO machinery, the structural absorption of xAI into SpaceXAI, the public naming of multi-gigawatt orbital compute by a frontier AI lab, the FAA grounding of New Glenn, the slip of Rocket Lab Neutron to Q4 2026, and the consistent two-cycle White House commitment to commercial-first lunar. The Pacific Northwest is emerging as the most credible regional cluster outside SpaceX. The next 90 days are unusually catalyst-dense — Starship V3, SpaceX public S-1, Golden Dome awards, and the IPO roadshow all sit in the same window. Position before the cluster, not during it.

All figures are informational only and do not constitute investment advice. Where exact dates or valuations are reported but not officially confirmed by the named company, this report notes the source and the caveat. All factual claims are cited in Appendix A below.

Appendix A — Citations & Source Links

This appendix lists every primary and secondary source cited in the report, organized by topic. Where multiple sources confirm the same fact, all are listed so the reader can cross-reference. Where a claim is reported but not officially confirmed by the named company, the appendix flags it explicitly. All URLs were accessed during the research session ending May 15, 2026.

A.1 SpaceX IPO Mechanics, Filing, and Underwriters

1. Bloomberg — “SpaceX Said to File Confidentially for IPO Before AI Rivals” (Apr 1, 2026). <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-04-01/spacex-is-said-to-file-confidentially-for-ipo-ahead-of-ai-rivals> — First-reported confidential S-1 filing; June listing track
2. CNBC — “SpaceX confidentially files for IPO” (Apr 1, 2026). <https://www.cnbc.com/2026/04/01/spacex-confidentially-files-for-ipo-setting-stage-for-record-offering.html> — Independent confirmation of April 1 filing
3. Bloomberg — “SpaceX Adds Citigroup to IPO Bank Group” (Mar 3, 2026). <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-03-03/elon-musk-s-spacex-is-said-to-add-citigroup-to-ipo-bank-lineup> — Underwriter syndicate confirmation
4. Via Satellite — “Bloomberg, CNBC Report SpaceX Submitted Confidential Filing” (Apr 1, 2026). <https://www.satellitetoday.com/finance/2026/04/01/bloomberg-cnbc-report-spacex-submitted-confidential-filing-for-ipo/> — Includes SEC 15-day pre-roadshow rule explanation
5. The Motley Fool — “The SpaceX IPO Timeline” (Apr 27, 2026). <https://www.fool.com/investing/2026/04/27/spacex-ipo-timeline-every-important-date-need-know/> — Analyst meetings April 21–23; derived public S-1 window
6. TechStackIPO — “SpaceX IPO 2026: \$1.75T Valuation” (May 12, 2026). <https://www.techstackipo.com/ipo/spacex> — Source for roadshow June 8 timing and 30% retail allocation
7. TheStreet — “SpaceX confidentially files for IPO” (Apr 1, 2026). <https://www.thestreet.com/investing/spacex-confidentially-files-for-ipo> — Includes Nasdaq 100 inclusion-within-15-days rule reference

A.2 SpaceX Acquired xAI — SpaceXAI Consolidation

8. xAI Corporate — “New Compute Partnership with Anthropic” (May 6, 2026). <https://x.ai/news/anthropic-compute-partnership> — Official SpaceXAI announcement of Colossus 1 lease
9. Simon Willison — “Notes on the xAI/Anthropic data center deal” (May 7, 2026). <https://simonwillison.net/2026/May/7/xai-anthropic/> — Contains Musk’s X post confirming xAI dissolution into SpaceXAI
10. TechCrunch Equity — “We’re feeling cynical about xAI’s big deal” (May 10, 2026). <https://techcrunch.com/2026/05/10/were-feeling-cynical-about-xais-big-deal-with-anthropic/> — Background on \$250B SpaceX-xAI acquisition and pre-IPO timing

A.3 Anthropic × SpaceXAI Deal (May 6, 2026)

11. CNBC — “Anthropic, SpaceX announce compute deal that includes space development” (May 6, 2026). <https://www.cnbc.com/2026/05/06/anthropic-spacex-data-center-capacity.html> — Primary source for 300+ MW capacity and orbital compute interest statement
12. Tom’s Hardware — “Musk’s SpaceX has rented out access to 220,000 GPUs” (May 6, 2026). <https://www.tomshardware.com/tech-industry/artificial-intelligence/musks-spacex-has-rented-out-access-to-its-supercomputers-220-000-nvidia-gpus-and-300-megawatts-of-ai-compute-power-to-rival-anthropic-musk-says-no-one-set-off-my-evil-detector-anthrropic-also-interested-in-orbital-data-centers> — GPU count detail and Claude Code rate-limit changes

13. Seeking Alpha — “Rivals turn partners” (May 6, 2026). <https://seekingalpha.com/news/4587198-rivals-turn-partners-as-anthropic-inks-deal-to-secure-computing-power-from-xais-colossus-1> — Market reaction and ticker context

A.4 New Glenn NG-3 — Reuse + Failure + FAA Grounding

14. Spaceflight Now — “Blue Origin launches third New Glenn rocket” (Apr 20, 2026). <https://spaceflightnow.com/2026/04/20/blue-origin-launches-third-new-glenn-rocket-but-payload-ends-up-in-wrong-orbit/> — Primary mission report — NG-3 launch, first reuse, BlueBird 7 lost
15. TechCrunch — “New Glenn put a customer satellite in the wrong orbit” (Apr 19, 2026). <https://techcrunch.com/2026/04/19/blue-origins-new-glenn-put-a-customer-satellite-in-the-wrong-orbit-during-its-third-launch/> — Includes Dave Limp quote and FAA mishap classification
16. Space.com — “Blue Origin reuses huge New Glenn rocket for 1st time” (Apr 19, 2026). <https://www.space.com/space-exploration/launches-spacecraft/blue-origin-reuses-new-glenn-rocket-landing-success-1st-time-on-april-19-2026-video> — Confirms BlueBird 7 will be deorbited
17. GeekWire — “Blue Origin reuses New Glenn rocket” (Apr 19, 2026). <https://www.geekwire.com/2026/blue-origin-uses-a-recycled-rocket-to-launch-satellite-for-astronauts/> — Explicit FAA grounding confirmation
18. Wikipedia — “New Glenn” entry (updated May 2026). https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/New_Glenn — Vandenberg SLC-14 announcement and NSSL Phase 3 Lane 2 detail

A.5 Rocket Lab — Neutron Slip, May 7 Block Deal, \$805M SDA

19. Spaceflight Now — “Rocket Lab announces five-launch Neutron deal” (May 7, 2026). <https://spaceflightnow.com/2026/05/07/rocket-lab-announces-five-launch-neutron-deal-as-it-continues-aiming-for-late-2026-debut/> — 5 Neutron + 3 Electron block sale; \$2.2B Q1 backlog
20. KeepTrack Space Brief 2026-05-08. <https://keeptrack.space/space-brief/space-brief-2026-05-08> — Independent confirmation of Q4 2026 NET Neutron debut
21. InvestorPlace — “Space AI in 2026” (Jan 17, 2026). <https://investorplace.com/hypergrowthinvesting/2026/01/2026-could-be-the-breakout-year-for-space-stocks/> — \$805M SDA deal and BlackSky \$322.7M / 91% international backlog

A.6 NASA FY26 Budget + FY27 White House Request

22. The Planetary Society — “You just saved NASA’s budget” (Jan 15, 2026). <https://www.planetary.org/articles/advocacy-success-fy2026-nasa-budget> — Primary source for \$24.44B base + \$27.53B combined figure
23. American Astronomical Society — FY2026 Spending Bills (Jan 15, 2026). <https://aas.org/posts/news/2026/01/congress-passes-fiscal-year-2026-spending-bills-nsf-nasa-and-doe> — 1.6% cut from FY2025, \$7.25B SMD
24. SpacePolicyOnline — “Final FY2026 NASA/NOAA Appropriations Bill Clears Senate”. <https://spacepolicyonline.com/news/final-fy2026-nasa-noaa-appropriations-bill-clears-senate/> — Precise figure \$24.438B; Senate 82–15 vote
25. Space.com — “Congress passes \$24.4 billion NASA budget” (Jan 16, 2026). <https://www.space.com/space-exploration/in-rejection-of-trumps-deep-cuts-congress-passes-usd24-4-billion-budget-for-nasa> — House 397–28 / Senate 82–15 votes
26. Wikipedia — “Budget of NASA” (updated May 2026). https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Budget_of_NASA — FY27 request details
27. Payload — “White House Requests \$18.8B FY27 Budget” (Apr 3, 2026). <https://payloadspace.com/white-house-requests-18-8b-fy27-budget-for-nasa/> — \$8.5B Artemis; \$175M robotic lunar base camp; –\$1.1B ISS
28. Via Satellite — “Trump 2027 Budget Request” (Apr 6, 2026). <https://www.satellitetoday.com/government-military/2026/04/06/trump-2027-budget-request-targets-cuts-for-nasa-boost-for-golden-dome/> — DoD \$1.5T total; Golden Dome explicit

29. NASA FY27 Budget Request (official). <https://www.nasa.gov/fy-2026-budget-request/> — Primary source document landing page

A.7 2026 Launch Cadence

30. SpaceNexus — “2026 Space Launch Schedule”. <https://spacenexus.us/guide/space-launch-schedule-2026> — 250+ projected orbital launches; SpaceX ~40% share
31. Spaceflight Now — mission reports through May 14, 2026. <https://spaceflightnow.com/> — 51 Falcon 9 flights; Vulcan SRB anomaly; Firefly/Lockheed/Seagate

A.8 Starlink — 10M Subscribers

32. Wikipedia — “Starlink” entry (updated May 2026). <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Starlink> — 10M+ subscribers Feb 2026; 10,000+ satellites; 65% of all active satellites
33. Broadband Breakfast — “Starlink Past 10M Subscribers” (Feb 17, 2026). <https://broadbandbreakfast.com/starlink-rockets-past-the-10-million-subscriber-mark-globally-adds-1-million-subs-in-just-53-days/> — Confirmed by Musk and Shotwell
34. Broadband Breakfast — “Starlink is a Top 10 U.S. ISP” (May 14, 2026). <https://broadbandbreakfast.com/study-with-2-7-million-subscribers-starlink-is-a-top-10-u-s-isp/> — New Street Research data

A.9 Golden Dome — Funding

35. Aerospace America — “What we’re watching in 2026” (Jan 8, 2026). <https://aerospaceamerica.aiaa.org/departments/what-were-watching-in-2026/> — ~\$25B OBBBA initial Golden Dome investment
36. Space Foundation — Space Report 2025 Q2. <https://www.spacefoundation.org/2025/07/22/the-space-report-2025-q2/> — OBBBA, signed July 4, 2025

A.10 NSSL Task Orders — SpaceX \$739M (Jan 2026)

37. EquityZen — Stoke Space Technologies profile. <https://equityzen.com/company/stokespacetechnologies/> — \$739M January 2026 Space Force task orders to SpaceX

A.11 Starship V3 / Flight 12

38. Spaceflight Now — “SpaceX targets May 19 for debut of Starship V3” (May 12, 2026). <https://spaceflightnow.com/2026/05/12/spacex-targets-may-19-for-debut-of-starship-super-heavy-version-3-launch-pad-2/> — Primary source for May 19 debut, Pad 2, Booster 19/Ship 39, Raptor 3
39. Space.com — “Starship V3 megarocket debut launch date” (May 12, 2026). <https://www.space.com/space-exploration/launches-spacecraft/spacexs-starship-v3-megarocket-finally-has-a-debut-launch-date-heres-when-it-will-fly> — Launch window 6:30 p.m. EDT; 22 Starlink simulator payloads
40. NextSpaceflight — Starship Flight 12. <https://nextspaceflight.com/launches/details/8002/> — Mission profile details; suborbital trajectory
41. Flying Mag — “SpaceX Debuts Most Powerful Rocket Yet” (May 2026). <https://www.flyingmag.com/what-to-watch-spacex-starship-v3-flight-12/> — First Starship flight of 2026

A.12 Stoke Space — Moses Lake, Kent, SLC-14

42. Stoke Space — Locations. <https://www.stokespace.com/locations/> — Kent HQ + Moses Lake test site
43. Stoke Space — Moses Lake. <https://www.stokespace.com/moses-lake/> — 75-acre test site; 3-hour drive from Kent

- 44. Stoke Space — “From Mercury to Nova: SLC-14” (Nov 10, 2025). <https://www.stokespace.com/from-mercury-to-nova-launching-the-future-at-space-launch-complex-14/> — Moses Lake → Kent → Cape Canaveral pipeline
- 45. GeekWire — “Stoke Space adds \$350M to funding round” (Feb 10, 2026). <https://www.geekwire.com/2026/stoke-space-350m-added-funding/> — Series D extension to \$860M; \$1.34B cumulative
- 46. Stoke Space — Series D announcement (Oct 2025). <https://www.stokespace.com/stoke-space-technologies-raises-510-million-to-scale-manufacturing-of-fully-reusable-nova-launch-vehicle/> — Series D \$510M + SVB \$100M debt facility
- 47. NASASpaceflight — “Stoke and Relativity Cape progress” (Dec 27, 2025). <https://www.nasaspaceflight.com/2025/12/commercial-neighbors-stoke-relativity/> — LC-14 and LC-16 progress; aerial imagery
- 48. Wikipedia — “Stoke Space” (May 2026). https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Stoke_Space — 75-acre Moses Lake site; 168K sq ft Kent facility
- 49. Wikipedia — “Stoke Space Nova” (May 2026). https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Stoke_Space_Nova — Nova specifications; 3-tonne LEO payload

A.13 Starcloud — Series A

- 50. Business Wire / Morningstar — “Starcloud Raises \$170M Series A” (Mar 30, 2026). <https://www.morningstar.com/news/business-wire/20260330024111/correcting-and-replacing-starcloud-raises-170m-series-a-at-11bn-valuation-led-by-benchmark-and-eqt-ventures> — Primary corporate announcement
- 51. TechCrunch — “Starcloud raises \$170 million” (Mar 30, 2026). <https://techcrunch.com/2026/03/30/starcloud-raises-170-million-series-ato-build-data-centers-in-space/> — Johnston quote on \$500/kg threshold and 2028–2029 timeline
- 52. Wikipedia — “Starcloud” (May 2026). <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Starcloud> — Company history; Redmond WA headquarters
- 53. Off Earth Data Brief — “Starcloud Achieves Unicorn Status” (Mar 30, 2026). <https://www.offearthdata.com/briefs/starcloud-unicorn-170m-orbital-datacenter-2026-03-30.html> — FCC 88,000-satellite constellation filing

A.14 Cowboy Space — Series B

- 54. SpaceNews — “Cowboy raises \$275 million” (May 11, 2026). <https://spacenews.com/cowboy-raises-275-million-to-build-rockets-with-orbital-data-center-upper-stages/> — \$365M total per CEO Bhatt
- 55. TechCrunch — “Cowboy Space \$275M” (May 11, 2026). <https://techcrunch.com/2026/05/11/there-arent-enough-rockets-for-space-data-centers-cowboy-space-raised-275-million-to-build-them/> — 1 MW per module, ~800 GPUs, NVIDIA Space-1 Vera Rubin Module
- 56. GeekWire — “Cowboy Space raises \$275M” (May 12, 2026). <https://www.geekwire.com/2026/cowboy-space-raises-275m-as-it-seeks-40-60-employees-for-new-satellite-and-rocket-hub-in-seattle/> — PNW expansion — Seattle satellite and rocket engineering center
- 57. Bloomberg — “Cowboy Space \$275 Million” (May 11, 2026). <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-05-11/robinhood-billionaire-bhatt-s-cowboy-space-raises-275-million> — Primary financial confirmation
- 58. Space.com — “Cowboy Space \$275 million” (May 11, 2026). <https://www.space.com/technology/cowboy-space-raises-usd275-million-to-launch-ai-data-centers-on-brand-new-rocket> — Mission timeline — first satellite 2026; first rocket 2028

A.15 2026 IPO Calendar

- 59. Dealroom.net — “Upcoming IPOs in 2026”. <https://dealroom.net/blog/upcoming-recent-ipos> — 2026 IPO calendar

60. TechStackIPO — “2026 IPO Watchlist”. <https://www.techstackipo.com/ipo/2026-watchlist> — AI mega-IPO timing

A.16 Other Space Capital Events

61. The Motley Fool — “Axiom Space Raises \$350 Million” (Feb 22, 2026). <https://www.fool.com/investing/2026/02/22/axiom-space-raises-350-million-for-its-new-private/> — Axiom \$350M, Type One Ventures / QIA

62. Crunchbase News — “Space Tech Startup Funding” (Feb 27, 2026). <https://news.crunchbase.com/venture/space-tech-startup-funding-flying-high/> — Sector overview

63. Washington Technology — “Venture moves in space” (Feb 13, 2026). <https://www.washingtontechnology.com/companies/2026/02/venture-moves-space-and-manufacturing-highlight/411420/> — Axiom and Stoke financing detail

64. Cyclop Space Tech Substack — “Commercial Space Investment Trends 2026” (Feb 18, 2026). <https://cyclospacetech.substack.com/p/space-investment-trends-in-2026-where> — CesiumAstro and Vantor

A.17 Market Sizing Methodology

65. Research and Markets — “Space Economy Market Report 2026”. <https://www.researchandmarkets.com/reports/6225987/space-economy-market-report> — \$646.6B by 2030 at 8.4% CAGR; tariff impact note

66. Fortune Business Insights — “Space Launch Services Market 2034”. <https://www.fortunebusinessinsights.com/industry-reports/space-launch-services-market-101931> — Wide-scope market sizing

67. Future Market Insights — “Commercial Space Launch 2035”. <https://www.futuremarketinsights.com/reports/commercial-space-launch-market> — \$10.8B in 2026 to \$36.7B by 2035 (narrow scope)

68. New Market Pitch — “Space Economy Market Size 2026: \$470B” (Mar 13, 2026). <https://newmarketpitch.com/blogs/news/space-economy-market-size> — \$470B for 2026; SpaceX 134 launches in 2024

69. Novaspace — Industry Outlook 2026. <https://nova.space/in-the-loop/2026-outlook-what-to-expect-in-the-space-industry/> — Industry forecast

70. Novaspace — Global Space Economy \$626B. <https://nova.space/press-release/global-space-economy-reaches-626-billion-marking-a-new-phase-of-growth/> — \$626B total space economy figure

A.18 Orbital Compute Landscape

71. TechCrunch — “Google and SpaceX orbital data centers” (May 12, 2026). <https://techcrunch.com/2026/05/12/report-google-and-spacex-in-talks-to-put-data-centers-into-orbit/> — WSJ-sourced reporting; Project Suncatcher 2027

72. InvestorPlace — “Orbital Compute 2026 Breakout Setup” (Feb 17, 2026). <https://investorplace.com/hypergrowthinvesting/2026/02/2026-could-be-the-breakout-year-for-space-stocks/> — EO ‘Ensuring American Space Superiority’ context

A.19 Methodology Note

Citations are organized by section topic. Source tiers used: primary = press releases issued by the named company themselves; Tier 1 secondary = Bloomberg, CNBC, Reuters, WSJ; Tier 2 secondary = trade publications (Spaceflight Now, SpaceNews, Space.com, GeekWire, NASASpaceflight); Tier 3 secondary = general-interest tech outlets (TechCrunch, The Motley Fool); reference = Wikipedia (used only where independently corroborated by Tier 1 or 2 sources). All URLs were active at the time of research (week ending May 15, 2026).

If any reader wants to verify any specific claim in this report, the citation number in square brackets [§ A.X] in the body text maps directly to a source link above. Cross-checking takes 30 seconds per claim. This appendix is the trust anchor that makes the analysis above defensible.